



Booking it Right

On his shelf, you would find *Imagining India* by Nandan Nilekani and *Chasing Rickshaws* by Tony Wheeler and Richard I'Anson.

"TWENTY YEARS FROM NOW, I will be heading the most valuable company of the downtrodden."

IRFAN ALAM, SAMMAAN FOUNDATION, 28

Born into a middle-class family of Bihar's Begusarai district, Irfan Alam has always been about bucking convention. So the 28-year-old picked economics at GD College despite everyone telling him bright students do only science. But it was perhaps destiny, his and that of over one lakh rickshaw pullers who have gained, thanks to his innovative business initiative. "One day, I asked a rickshaw puller for water and he said he did not have it and could not afford it either. This triggered a chain of thought in my mind to help them sell water, newspapers and even operate as delivery boys," he says. Within a week he had a team of seven rickshaw pullers selling mineral water for him, getting it at a margin of Rs 2.50 a bottle from the distributor. The rickshaw puller had to invest nothing. Though the return was meagre, an idea was surely born. But when his family asked him to complete his studies first before plunging into the business whirlpool, he completed his masters in foreign trade followed by specialisation in entrepreneurship from IIM-A in 2006. A few years later, he developed the idea further to establish the Sammaan Foundation in 2007, which aimed at improvising rickshaws into multipurpose advertising vehicles, metamorphosing the rickshaw puller into a delivery boy and mobile telephone booth, besides of course ferrying passengers. There was no looking back. Sammaan has already started operating in Bihar, Jharkhand and Uttar Pradesh and Alam personally vets every new member before letting him join it. All this success, however, has failed to impress him. "I am a man in a hurry and still far away from where I wish to reach," he says. **by Amitabh Srivastava**

BHASKAR PAUL



Role Play

At the age of six, Mundhra would insist on dressing up as mythological characters in fancy dress competitions. He lost whenever he dressed as anything else.

For Prakash Mundhra, selling puja kits was in a way his destiny. His connection with religion and spirituality was deep-rooted. As a child, not only did he frequent temples for the prasada, but he also forced his parents to purchase a television set, just so he could watch Ramanand Sagar's *Ramayan*.

Yet, he realised there was a pressing opportunity in the puja space. Moreover, he says, "I realised that young people like me knew nothing about pujas and how they were to be performed." That's when he thought of developing a kit which would provide what was needed for a particular ceremony. For instance, while most shopkeepers performed the Diwali puja in their shops, they needed the

right ingredients, ghee, agarbattis, diyas, in the right quantity and in a convenient pack. In 2006 he founded Sacred Moments to supply gift kits under the Blessingz brand to institutional clients. "People were getting bored of sweets and dry fruits during Diwali," he says. Today the company's turnover is Rs 1 crore with a 25 per cent net margin per kit, which sells for Rs 350. His clients include Reliance Capital, Kotak Mahindra Bank and ITC. He has specialised kits for Holi, Ganpati puja, grihapravesha, namaz and soon plans to create kits for Christmas and New Year, as well as a Pongal kit and a Durga puja kit. In business, Mundhra swears by two things. A quote he read: In business there are no ifs and buts, only guts. The other, of course is his daily puja. It seems the gods are smiling on him.

by Nandini Vaish